

21, Concerning the Islamic Feudal System and the Problem of Its Incomplete Development

The next exceptionally fascinating—and simultaneously highly controversial—problem concerns the **feudal system** (or rather, the **quasi-feudal system** [准封建制度]) of the medieval Islamic world, and the precise disparities between it and the "standardized feudal system" experienced by Western Europe.

*(Naturally, because the Islamic world was so overwhelmingly vast, monumentally complex, and its **feudalization** so incomplete, it is fundamentally impossible to pinpoint an exact chronological boundary between classical Islamic society and medieval Islamic society; we can only formulate nebulous judgments).*

During the rule of the Buyid Dynasty (白益王朝) in Iran, hereditary political enfeoffment (*enfeoffing royal kin*) and the **Iqta system** (伊克塔制度) materialized simultaneously. Considering that the ruling family of this dynasty overtly claimed royal descent from the Sasanian Dynasty, and deliberately resurrected numerous symbols and customs of pre-Islamic Iran, this empire was undeniably driven by Iranians who had merely converted to Islam.

The fact that the **Iqta system**—which later became ubiquitous across the Islamic world—first emerged under the rule of this specific dynasty proves, largely in retrospect, that the **landlord class** (地主阶级) that had already risen in Iran was fundamentally not severely impacted by the Islamic conquest. The Islamic conquest's actual impact on Iran's socio-historical evolutionary trajectory was exceptionally limited.

However, over the ensuing five to six centuries—right up until the moment European galleons ran rampant across the Indian Ocean—the **feudal system** across the entire Islamic world failed to experience any massive developmental leaps. It completely failed to coalesce into a heavily stratified **feudal system** with rigidly defined rights and obligations akin to the European Middle Ages.

"The *Iqta system* was fundamentally a system that granted land revenue rights to those bearing military obligations; it was not only theoretically non-hereditary but also a temporary arrangement with fixed terms, rather than life tenure." Let alone being theoretically hereditary, it was not even a lifelong tenure, frequently possessing strict expiration dates.

Contemporary observers are far too inclined to explain this away as a product of "cultural disparities"—especially emphasizing the supposed doctrinal and jurisprudential chasm between Islam and Christianity, two global religions. I certainly do not deny that this is a contributing factor, but I vehemently insist upon my core thesis: **Religious and cultural differences were absolutely not the primary cause, and it had even less to do with ethnic characteristics.**

My contention is this: The primary reason the medieval Islamic world has perpetually appeared in our historical memory as a society with incomplete **feudalization** (封建化) is absolutely not because it possessed some hyper-unique developmental pathway. It is simply because its **feudalization** process commenced significantly later, and was subsequently, relentlessly, violently interrupted and obliterated by successive waves of nomadic conquerors.

At least two highly explicit pieces of evidence can definitively substantiate this view.

The first piece of evidence is this: a feudal system defined by multi-tiered subinfeudation (层层分封), where the lord-vassal relationship and landholdings are transmitted hereditarily through generations (as seen in the European Middle Ages), fundamentally did not emerge overnight at the very beginning.

When the *Benefice* (采邑制) system first materialized in the Frankish Kingdom (法兰克王国) in Western Europe, it identically prohibited aristocrats and military men from passing it down hereditarily. The king granted the *usufruct* (土地的使用权) or mere revenue rights of the land to a minister as a reward, forging a contractual relationship—frequently translated into Chinese as "Retinue System" (扈从制 / Vassalage). The ennobled aristocrat pledged fealty to the king and provided military service, while the king bore the reciprocal obligation to protect his noble vassals.

However, the *Benefice* system during the Frankish Kingdom was emphatically *not* hereditary. The king retained the absolute right to revoke the granted land, and the vassalage relationship was fundamentally not stably transmitted across generations. It was only during the catastrophic decline and fragmentation of the Carolingian Dynasty (加洛林王朝) that granted lands were gradually usurped by their holders as hereditary estates. The possession of partial rights over the land violently expanded into absolute land ownership. Consequently, the fealty relationship between vassal and lord also began to perpetuate across generations. **By the High Middle Ages (11th to 13th centuries), the Western European feudal system had finally matured.**

Even in the distant East, in Japan—a nation that organically evolved a feudal structure remarkably similar to the European model—the *Samurai* (武士) class identically retained a non-hereditary reward system (恩赏制度) during their initial seizure of power. For instance, during the Kamakura period (镰仓时代), the *Shugo* (守护 / Military Governors) and the lower-ranking *Jito* (地头 / Estate Stewards) were appointed directly by the Shogunate (幕府), were absolutely non-hereditary, and could be arbitrarily replaced or dismissed. Similarly, the *Jito* fundamentally did not possess absolute ownership of the land; they merely earned annual tribute as remuneration by providing services such as maintaining public security and collecting taxes for the grand manorial lords (庄园主).

It was not until the mid-Muromachi period (室町时代中期)—more than two entire centuries after the establishment of the Kamakura Shogunate—that the Japanese Samurai class comprehensively mutated into genuine *feudal lords* (封建领主) governing hereditary fiefdoms on a national scale.

In regions like Western Europe and Japan, where myriad factors were exceptionally and perfectly conducive to *feudalization*, it still took over two entire centuries for the rights of the lords to evolve from non-hereditary *usufructs* to hereditary, absolute land ownership.

Here, I must clarify a problem encountered in the preceding paragraph. Because, no matter how advanced Western Europe is today, Europeans over a millennium ago could not possibly possess the legal consciousness of modern individuals. Therefore, it is exceedingly difficult for us to flawlessly map the rights recognized by people of that era onto modern concepts like "land ownership" (土地所有权) and "land property rights" (土地产权) without any deviation.

When I stated that the early *Benefice* (采邑) still did not equate to the granting of land ownership, it actually meant that the possessor of the benefice was fundamentally unable to dispose of it as private property—for instance, freely alienating it or engaging in **subinfeudation** (次一级的分封).

This was historically inevitable at the time. Because the hereditary possession of benefices was not yet universal, if a vassal's own land was, at best, held for a single generation before being revoked, how could he possibly establish secondary loyalty relationships centered around himself?

By the 12th century, once the hereditary nature of feudal land grants was universally recognized across Western Europe, the sale, alienation, and subinfeudation of benefices faced scarcely any restrictions—though naturally, in some cases, approval from the superior lord was still required.

Simultaneously, one must absolutely never forget that not all lands belonging to **feudal lords** in medieval Europe were acquired as remuneration for military service under a feudal relationship. In France and Germany, some formidable grand aristocrats loyal to the French King or German Emperor (*e.g.*, *immensely powerful Dukes*) acquired their ruling status in the exact same manner as their suzerains—namely, by evolving directly from tribal chieftains into **feudal lords**.

Under such circumstances, their hereditary rule over their own territories was self-evident. Their fealty to the King or Caesar was fundamentally driven by pragmatic calculations of family interests; after all, the French King and German Emperor were undeniably the preeminent figures among the **feudal lords**. These grand aristocrats intrinsically possessed vast hereditary territories *prior* to establishing feudal vassalage relationships with superior rulers, rather than being transformed into the ruling class solely because they were granted land to serve a superior lord.

Only England, following the Norman Conquest (诺曼征服), was the absolute exception. Through twenty years of relentless warfare, William I (威廉一世) systematically stripped and redistributed virtually all the land in England, ensuring that England no longer possessed the type of **feudal lords** that had evolved from tribal leaders on the European continent. Consequently, the phenomenon of "multiple vassalage" (多重臣属)—where a single individual simultaneously swears fealty to multiple lords—was drastically eradicated in England. Feudal relationships became crystal clear and highly stable. This not only rendered the English royal power exceptionally formidable at the time, but crucially granted the English a monumental head start throughout the entire historical trajectory.

In the medieval Islamic world, however, the favorable conditions for **feudalization** were inherently far fewer, and one can visibly observe the emergence of numerous highly unfavorable conditions.

For instance, because the Islamic world was situated exactly at the geopolitical epicenter of the Eurasian landmass, its commercial activities were phenomenally hyper-developed, its economy was vastly more diversified, and its urban culture remained perpetually prosperous. While superficially these undeniably cannot be deemed negative, this high degree of circulation and flexible social hierarchy was extraordinarily detrimental to the formation of the **manor system** (庄园制度)—which constitutes the **economic base**—under the developmental conditions of a **natural economy** (自然经济).

This was already highly prohibitive to the universal emergence of hereditary fiefdoms; after all, the indispensable economic bedrock that allows **feudal lords** to secure a political foothold is the **manor** possessed across generations.

Furthermore, the external incursions faced by the Islamic world were simply far too ferocious and agonizingly frequent. In the Middle East, it is fundamentally impossible to find a 200-year window of uninterrupted holistic peace that would allow the **feudal system** to organically develop further.

With relentless waves of Turkic and Mongol invaders aggressively crashing into this region, expecting the **Iqta system** (伊克塔制度) to organically evolve into the mature feudal system of the European *High Middle Ages* is simply unrealistic.

The second piece of explicit evidence is that the Iqta system was fundamentally not immutable across all regions of the Islamic world. It did not perpetually manifest strictly as a system where the *Muqti* (穆克提 / the holder of the Iqta) merely collected land revenue (*possessing only Revenue Rights*), managed general administration, completely abstained from interfering in the production and lives of the "subjects" (领民), provided zero public goods to their "fiefdom," and remained non-hereditary.

In Islamic India, during the rule of the Delhi Sultanate (德里苏丹国), the traditional **Iqta system** mutated into a feudal land grant known as the **Jagir** (贾吉尔). It is widely documented that the *Jagir* underwent further evolution, ultimately morphing into the **Zamindar system** (柴明达尔制度) during the era of the British conquest of India. The individual granted the land by the monarch was known as the **Jagirdar** (贾吉尔达).

Theoretically speaking, the *Jagir* was undeniably also a lifelong property tenure. The *Jagirdar* who was granted the *Jagir* was required to organize armies and undertake military service for the state. The remuneration he acquired was the power to administer and extract taxes from the manors (*retaining a portion for himself*). However, it was identically non-hereditary; upon the death of the grantee, the land was required to be returned to the state.

Yet, during the reign of Firuz (菲鲁兹), the third Sultan of the Tughlaq Dynasty (图格雷克王朝) of the Delhi Sultanate, this Sultan began to universally permit the Jagir to become a hereditary right. A military aristocrat could now officially dispatch his son, son-in-law, or even a slave to succeed his *Jagir*. Firuz implemented myriad other measures highly favorable to the *Jagirdar* aristocracy, including increasing their revenue share and mitigating punishments.

Consequently, in actual political practice, the **Iqta system** under the rule of Islamic India systematically mutated into a hereditary power. Certain phenomenally powerful *Jagirdars* later transformed during the Mughal Empire (莫卧儿帝国) era into semi-autonomous Muslim rulers of princely states, translated into Chinese as **Nawab** (纳瓦卜).

I maintain that this is a phenomenally fascinating dynamic. If we meticulously observe the chronological timetable of the **feudalization** process in the Middle East (*particularly Iran*) versus the timetable in India (*particularly Northern India*), it becomes glaringly obvious that the latter commenced significantly earlier than the former.

When the Gupta Empire was collapsing into ruin, the Sasanian Dynasty was aggressively marching toward its zenith. While the Rajputs (拉杰普特人) were waging ceaseless wars across Northern India, the Arab Empire was still artificially prolonging the **classical society** (古典社会) of the Middle East. Throughout the entirety of the Middle Ages (*Middle Ages strictly in the European chronological sense*), it is utterly unsurprising that the degree of **feudalization** in Northern India was astronomically higher than in the Middle East, especially the Iranian region.

The historical reality that Northern India stands as one of the exceedingly rare regions globally to successfully resurrect its indigenous religion after enduring protracted rule by Islamic regimes, serves as formidable collateral evidence for this point. Therefore, the **feudal system** under Islamic

rule was absolutely not inherently incapable of adapting to its environment; it was perfectly capable of seamlessly accommodating localized conditions. This perfectly aligns with the conclusion from the previous chapter: Islamic doctrines and jurisprudence (*religious law*) are identically capable of absolute environmental adaptation.

Simultaneously, we can observe that although the **Iqta system** (伊克塔制度) undeniably trended toward hereditary transmission under the highly specific conditions of India, its progress in aggressively expanding land property rights (土地产权) remained agonizingly sluggish. As previously stated when discussing India's **feudalization** process, India's natural and humanistic environments were fundamentally antagonistic to the genesis of explicit, unambiguous consciousness regarding **land ownership** (土地所有权). Consequently, the *Zamindars* (柴明达尔) possessed virtually zero economic incentive to engage in land improvement (土地改良).

In India, whatever historical progression the indigenous Indian society was organically capable of achieving, Islam—upon arrival—was forced to "hold its nose" (捏着鼻子) and adapt to it. Conversely, whatever structural transformations the indigenous society was fundamentally incapable of accomplishing, Islam was equally impotent to execute.

It was not until the British colonizers gradually subjugated the entire Indian subcontinent in the late 18th and early 19th centuries that they forcefully legally designated the *Zamindars* as absolute land owners. Many of these immensely powerful *Zamindars* subsequently evolved into rulers of princely states (土邦) under British suzerainty—but this was a phenomenally recent, exogenous historical development.

Consequently, I conclude that the fundamental reason the **Iqta system** failed to organically evolve into the highly rigorous, meticulously structured feudal apparatus witnessed during the Western European *High Middle Ages* was, in the final analysis, that the Islamic world was cursed with several highly unfavorable natural and human geographical conditions. **Moreover, Heaven simply did not grant them sufficient developmental time.**

In the Islamic world of North Africa, excluding Egypt—namely, the Maghreb region (马格里布地区)—the progression of social development was inevitably even more agonizingly protracted. From a macroscopic geopolitical perspective, this region is essentially nothing more than a fractured, exceedingly narrow strip of habitable land sandwiched violently between the ocean and the desert-mountains. In many places, such as the Libyan region (利比亚地区), this narrow ribbon is physically severed. The dawn of civilization here was exponentially later than in the Levant (中东地区 / The Near East).

Furthermore, at the twilight of the first millennium AD, a colossal trade network suddenly materialized on the southern flank of the Maghreb, forcefully sucking the region into its vortex: this was the Trans-Saharan Trade (跨撒哈拉贸易). An endless torrent of gold from the mysterious lands of the south flowed relentlessly along commercial routes strung together by oases, ultimately pouring into the Mediterranean world.

Due to this massive commercial influx, **feudalization** in the Maghreb region was doomed to be exceptionally inconspicuous. **Tribal groups** (部族) or massive tribal confederacies perpetually monopolized towering positions within state politics, and the region remained excessively politically fragmented. Therefore, the phenomenon of **feudalization** here could only remain

permanently locked in a highly primitive, embryonic state: merely acknowledging the ad hoc domination of land strictly in exchange for immediate military service.

21，关于伊斯兰封建制度及其发展不充分的问题

接下来一个有意思的同时争议颇大的问题就是中世纪伊斯兰世界的封建制度（当然由于伊斯兰世界太过庞大，复杂并且封建化不充分，不可能准确指出古典伊斯兰社会和中世纪伊斯兰社会的分界点，我们只能做出模糊的判断），或者说准封建制度与西欧所经历的“标准的封建制度”存在的差异。在伊朗的白益王朝（Buyid）统治时期，世袭的政治分封（分封亲族）和伊克塔制度（iqta）一并出现了。考虑到该王朝的统治家族自称具有萨珊王朝的皇室血统，有意识地复兴了许多伊朗在伊斯兰征服前的象征和习俗，该帝国确实也是皈依伊斯兰教的伊朗人。伊斯兰世界广泛存在的伊克塔制度首先在该王朝统治下出现在很大程度上从事后说明了伊朗已经崛起的地主阶级并没有在伊斯兰征服中受到太多影响，伊斯兰征服对于伊朗的社会发展进程上影响十分有限。然而接下来五六个世纪直到欧洲的帆船在印度洋横行无忌的时候，整个伊斯兰世界的封建制度并没有太大的发展，没有形成欧洲中世纪那样等级森严，权利和义务明确的封建制度。伊克塔制本质上是一种将土地收益权授予军事义务承担者的制度，不要说理论上难以世袭，甚至是有授予期限的非终身制。现在的人太过倾向于把这解释为文化上的差异，当然尤其是伊斯兰教与基督教两个世界性宗教在教义和教法上的差别。我当然不认为这不是原因，但是我坚持我的看法：宗教和文化上的差异绝非主要的，跟民族什么的更加不沾边了。我的观点是，中世纪伊斯兰世界之所以一直以这种封建化不完全的形象出现在人们的历史记忆中，不是因为他有什么极为独特的发展道路，而是主要因为其封建化进程本身起步要晚，又不断被游牧征服者打断和破坏。

至少有两个非常明确的证据可以证明这个观点，第一个证据是像欧洲中世纪这样层层封建，领主和封臣的关系通过世袭世代相传的封建制度也不是在一开始就形成的。当西欧的采邑制最早出现在法兰克王国时，同样并非允许贵族和军人世袭传承。国王将土地的使用权或者仅仅是收入权授予大臣作为回报，形成了一种在中国翻译为“扈从制”的契约关系，获得恩赐的贵族效忠国王，并为其提供军事服务，国王也有保护麾下贵族的义务。然而法兰克王国时期的采邑制度的确不是世袭的，国王可以收回恩赐的土地，扈从关系也没有在代际间稳定传递。在加洛林王朝衰落和分裂的过程中，恩赐的土地逐渐被领有者世袭，对土地的部分权利的占有扩大到了拥有土地所有权，封臣对于领主的效忠关系也在世代间延续，到 11 至 13 世纪中世纪盛期，西欧封建制度已经成熟了。即使是在遥远的东方发展出了与欧洲封建体制类似封建制的日本，武士在掌权之初也保留了非世袭的恩赏制度，例如镰仓时期的守护以及更下级的地头就由幕府任命而非世袭，并且可以撤换罢免。地头同样没有土地的所有权，而是通过为庄园主提供维持治安和征税这样的服务获取年贡报酬。日本武士阶级在全国范围内基本转化成为治理世袭领地的封建领主，也要等到镰仓幕府建立两个多世纪后的室町时代中期。在西欧和日本这样各种因素都十分有利于封建化的地方，领主的权利从非世袭和部分土地产权发展到世袭和土地所有权都用了两个多世纪的时间。

这里我解释一下上一段会遇到问题，因为无论西欧在今天多么先进，一千多年前的欧洲人无论如何也不可能具有现代人的法律意识，因此我们很难将当时人们所认识的权利与现在的“土地所有权”，“土地产权”这些概念进行毫无偏差的对应。我这里所说的采邑在最初仍然不属于土地所有权的授予，其实指的是采邑的所有者仍然无法像处置自己的私产一样处置采邑，例如对采邑进行自由转让或者次一级的分封。这在当时是必然的，因为采邑的世袭领有尚且没有普遍，如果封臣自己的土地都充其量持有一代人便被收回，那么他怎么建立围绕自己的次级效忠关系呢？等到 12 世纪的时候，封建土地授予的世袭性质在欧洲西部得到普遍承认之后，采邑的出卖、转让和分封也就没有什么限制了，当然有些情况下还是需要上级领主批准。

同时千万不能忘记中世纪欧洲所有隶属于封建领主的土地并不都是通过封建关系下进行军事服役所取得的报酬。在法国和德国，一些效忠于法王和德皇的大贵族，例如实力强大的公爵，其家族取得统治的方式与自己的封君没有不同，也即从部落首领封建化为封建领主。在这种情况下他们对于自己领地的世袭统治是不必多言的，他们对国王或凯撒效忠，本质上是出于对于家族利益的考量，毕竟法王和德皇在封建领主中肯定是佼佼者。这些大贵族是原本自己就有广大的世袭领地，然后与上级统治者建立了封建臣属关系，而不是被赐予了土地才转变为统治阶级为上级领主效忠。只有诺曼征服之后的英国最为特殊，威廉一世通过 20 年的征战几乎将英格兰所有土地剥夺并且再分配了一遍，使英格兰不再有欧洲大陆那种由部族领袖转化而来的封建领主。这样一个人同时向多个领主宣誓效忠的多重臣属现象在英格兰就被大幅消灭了，封建关系清晰且稳定，这不仅在当时使得英格兰的王权更加强大，并且让英国人在整个历史进程中占了先机。

而在中世纪的伊斯兰世界，本身封建化的有利条件就没那么多，而且人们可以明显看到还出现了不少不利条件。比如说伊斯兰世界因为其处于欧亚大陆中心的位置商业活动极其发达，经济多元化的多，城市文化也一直繁盛。这些虽然在表面上的确不能说是坏事，但是高度的流通，灵活的社会等级对于在自然经济发展的情况下形成构成经济基础的庄园制度非常不利。这就已经很不利于世袭领地的普遍出现，毕竟封建领主得以在政治上立足的经济根基就是世代拥有的庄园。而且伊斯兰世界面对的外部侵扰实在是太强也太频繁，在中东这个地区，根本找不到 200 年整体太平的，能够让封建制度自己进一步发展的时候，一波一波的突厥人和蒙古人频繁侵入这个区域，指望伊克塔制度能够演变成欧洲中世纪盛期的封建制度就不现实了。

第二个证据是伊克塔制度在伊斯兰世界的各个地区并非一成不变，并非永远以穆克提（Muqti，伊克塔的拥有者）仅仅收取土地收入并负责一般行政管理，完全不干涉“领民”的生产生活，不对自己的“领地”提供公共产品并且也不世袭的面目出现。在伊斯兰印度，传统的伊克塔制度于德里苏丹国统治时期演变成为一种叫作贾吉尔（Jagir）的封建土地授予，据说贾吉尔经过演变在日后英国征服印度时期形成了柴明达尔制度（Zamindar），被君主授予土地的人叫作贾吉尔达（Jagirdar）。从理论上讲，贾吉尔毫无疑问也是一种终身制财产，被授予贾吉尔的贾吉尔达需要组织军队并为国家承担军事服役，其获取的报酬是管理和从庄园征税的权力（部分自己留用），但是也不可以世袭，土地在受赐者死后应该返还国家。

然而在德里苏丹国图格雷克王朝（Tughlaq）第三任苏丹菲鲁兹统治时，这位苏丹开始普遍允许贾吉尔成为一种世袭权利，军事贵族可以派他的儿子，女婿甚至奴隶接替自己的贾吉尔，并且采取了其他有利于贾吉尔达贵族的措施，包括提高分成和减轻惩罚。于是在政治实践中，伊斯兰印度统治下的伊克塔制度就逐渐演变为了一种世袭权力。某些强大的贾吉尔达后来在莫卧儿帝国时期转变成为半自治的土邦穆斯林统治者，在汉语中被翻译为纳瓦卜（Nawab）。

我认为这是非常有意思的，因为如果我们观察中东地区（特别是伊朗）封建化进程的时间表和印度（特别是北印度）封建化进程的时间表，就很容易看到后者要比前者早了很多。在笈多帝国崩溃的时候，萨珊王朝正趋向鼎盛；当拉杰普特人在北印度南征北战的时候，阿拉伯帝国还在延续中东的古典社会。在整个中世纪（对于欧洲人而言的中世纪），北印度的封建化程度比中东尤其是伊朗地区更高的确不足为奇，而北印度作为世界上少有的在被伊斯兰政权长期统治之后仍然恢复本土宗教的地区的事实从侧面印证了这一点。因此伊斯兰教统治下的封建制度绝非不会适应环境，而是完全能够适应当地的环境，这和上一章节所说的伊斯兰教义和教法也能够完全适应环境是一致的。我们也能看到尽管在印度的特殊环境下伊克塔制度确实向世袭的方向发展了，但是在扩大土地产权的这个方面却进展缓慢。正如之前提到印度封建化进程时所说的，印度的自然环境和人文环境并不利于明晰的土地所有权意识产生，柴明达尔很

难有动力进行土地改良。在印度，印度当地社会能够实现的历史进程，伊斯兰教来了也必须捏着鼻子适应；当地社会所完成不了的变革，伊斯兰教到了也一样完成不了。

直到英国殖民者在 18 世纪末 19 世纪初逐渐统治整个印度次大陆的时候，他们将柴明达尔指定为土地所有者，很多强大的柴明达尔演变成为英国治下的土邦，这已经是极为晚近的事了。因此我认为，伊克塔制度之所以没有演变向西欧中世纪盛期那样严密的封建体制，归根到底还是伊斯兰世界存在一些不利的自然和人文地理条件，上天也没有给他们足够的发展时间。在除埃及外北非的伊斯兰世界（也就是马格里布地区），社会发展的进程只能更加缓慢，因为这片地区从总体上的形势来看无非是夹在海洋和沙漠山地之间的窄长的宜居土地罢了，甚至这条窄长的线在很多地方都是断的，比如利比亚地区。这里的文明起步也要比中东地区晚得多得多。而在公元第一个千年的最后，一个庞大的贸易网络出现在马格里布地区的南侧并将其卷入其中，这就是跨撒哈拉贸易，黄金通过绿洲串起的商业路线源源不断地从南方的神秘之地被输送到地中海世界。因此在马格里布地区封建化就会特别不明显，部落或者更大的部族在国家政治中占据的地位非常高，政治上又过于分裂，其封建化现象只能长期停留在一种原始的承认土地支配来换取军事服役的模式中。